



T20I classic that had singles as its base and explosive scoops over fine leg as its glittering crown. He saved India the blushes and the host eventually prevailed over the USA by 29 runs. The skipper's knock epitomised his 360-degree skills as no part of the ground was ignored and the USA fielders scampered around.

Hyderabadi zest

Mohammed Siraj was putting his feet up in Hyderabad when an SOS call from the Indian team management forced him to fly to Mumbai. And within 24 hours, he had played for India and grabbed three wickets to fashion a fine win. "It is all uparwala's (God's) will," he kept repeating in the post-match press conference.

K.C. Vijaya Kumar

Chennai, in Black and Teal

The M.A. Chidambaram Stadium has long been a sanctuary for cricket purists. But during the ongoing T20 World Cup, it also became the setting for a story that defied familiar Indian sporting patterns.

Packed houses in the country are usually reserved for high-stakes India matches or the presence of icons. Yet Chepauk witnessed something rarer: a "neutral" fixture

that felt anything but subdued.

A staggering 21,266 people poured into the stands to watch New Zealand take on Afghanistan, underlining that Chennai's passion for the game can stretch beyond national borders.

Much of the energy in the stadium was directed towards the Blackcaps, fuelled by the yellow thread that connects New Zealand's stalwarts to the Chennai Super Kings. That bond turned Chepauk into a sea of black and teal, punctuated by a roar that left little doubt about who the crowd had come to support.

Among those in the stands was Sukumar Thangaraj, an assistant professor and an ardent New Zealand fan since childhood.

Having followed the Blackcaps for years, he arrived with the tempered expectations of a seasoned supporter used to cheering in relative isolation. He anticipated a thin crowd, convinced that the 11:00 AM start and the scorching sun would keep all but a handful of niche fans away.

The day, however, offered a swift correction. Instead of a sparse audience, he found a vibrant community armed with massive flags and personalised banners.

"I was surprised with the kind of

A rare sight in India: a packed Chepauk for a non-India game, as Chennai rallied behind the Blackcaps against Afghanistan. R. RAGU

reception that we got. It wasn't just through chants and whistles. People had huge flags and I even saw a banner for Mitchell Santner," he said.

For Sukumar, the match also carried personal significance. It was the first sporting event he chose to attend with his wife. And the highlight arrived unexpectedly: a photograph of the couple was featured on the Chennai Super Kings' official Instagram handle, a moment of digital recognition that became the perfect finishing touch.

"I've always had a soft corner for CSK despite not being an avid IPL follower due to the NZ connection. However, my wife follows them and seeing our photo on Instagram was a pleasant surprise for both of us," he added.

New Zealand eventually sealed a five-wicket win, but the lasting memory of the afternoon had less to do with the scorecard and more with the mood inside the ground. The "knowledgeable Chennai crowd" had once again lived up to its reputation.

Nigamanth P